

Which Awards Do You Determine?

Most science fairs have two kinds of awards: awards from the fair and awards from external organizations. At ISEF these two kinds of awards are named, respectively, Grand Awards and Special Awards.

Here we compare Grand Awards and Special Awards from Special Award Organizations (SAO).

	Grand Awards	Special Awards
Criteria	Set by the fair	Set by the SAO
Judges	Recruited by the fair	Recruited by the SAO
Cash Award	Funded by the fair	Funded by the SAO
Judges consider	Only projects in their category	Projects from multiple categories may be in contention for a single award.
Award Organization	First, Second, Third, and Fourth	Different for each SAO

You are a Grand Award judge. You will work with judges in one and only one of ISEF's 21 categories to determine every Grand Award given in that category.

Because of conflicting time demands, it is impossible for any judge to serve as both a Grand Award judge and a judge for any Special Award Organization (SAO). If you have signed up for both tasks, you will have to withdraw from one of them.

What Are the Grand Awards?

Award	Amount
First Award	\$5,000
Second Award	\$2,000
Third Award	\$1,000
Fourth Award	\$ 500

All First Awards are equivalent to each other, just as all Second Awards are equivalent to each other, and so on. Your category's First Awards will be considered for further awards as discussed below under "Top Fair Awards."

How Many Projects Will Get an Award?

The exact number of awards in each category depends upon the number of projects in the category. Since the project counts are different in every category, so are the award counts. Your category will learn the number of awards at each level when you begin caucusing. However, as a guide ahead of time, we can say that the fraction of projects in each category which will receive *some* Grand Award is about one-quarter.

Every award level in every category will have at least one project. Depending upon the number of projects in the category there may or may not be more than one First Award project, but in most cases, there will be an increasing number of projects receiving Second, Third, and Fourth Awards respectively.

What if we can't decide between two projects?

If your category has been allocated N awards at a given level (for example, five projects for Fourth Award), you must select exactly N projects to receive those awards. You cannot fail to distinguish between the last two projects and declare a "tie" between them in order to give that award to $N + 1$ projects.

Within the set of projects receiving a single named award, some judges will think project A is better than project B, while others will think the reverse. Your category caucus does not need to make any decision about the relative merits of different projects receiving the same award.

Top Fair Awards

In addition to category-specific awards, ISEF will present a few other Top Awards:

- \$75,000 –George D. Yancopoulos Innovator Award of \$75,000
- \$50,000 - Regeneron Young Scientist Award (2 projects)
- \$50,000 – The Gordon E. Moore Award for Positive Outcomes
- \$10,000 – Craig R. Barrett Award for Innovation
- \$10,000 – Robert Horvitz Prize for Fundamental Research
- \$10,000 – Peggy Scripps Award for Science Communication
- Experiential Trips:
 - Dudley R. Herschbach SIYSS Award (up to 3 projects)
 - European Union Contest for Young Scientists Award (up to 3 students)

To determine the fair's Top Awards, a distinguished panel of judges selected by the Society for Science will review each First Award project display, along with additional information provided by the category caucus explaining the reason for the project's selection.

Points of Emphasis

1. You are a Grand Award judge.
2. Each caucus of Grand Award judges in a single category determines all fair awards in that category.
3. You cannot be both a Grand Award judge and an SAO judge.